

noise guaranteed

ASSETS '26 · QUEEN'S UNIVERSITY BELFAST · IMPERIAL COLLEGE LONDON

Who makes music software accessible?

The Qualities of Convivial Tools and Their Relevance to Music Software Accessibility. ACM TACCESS 18(3), 2025

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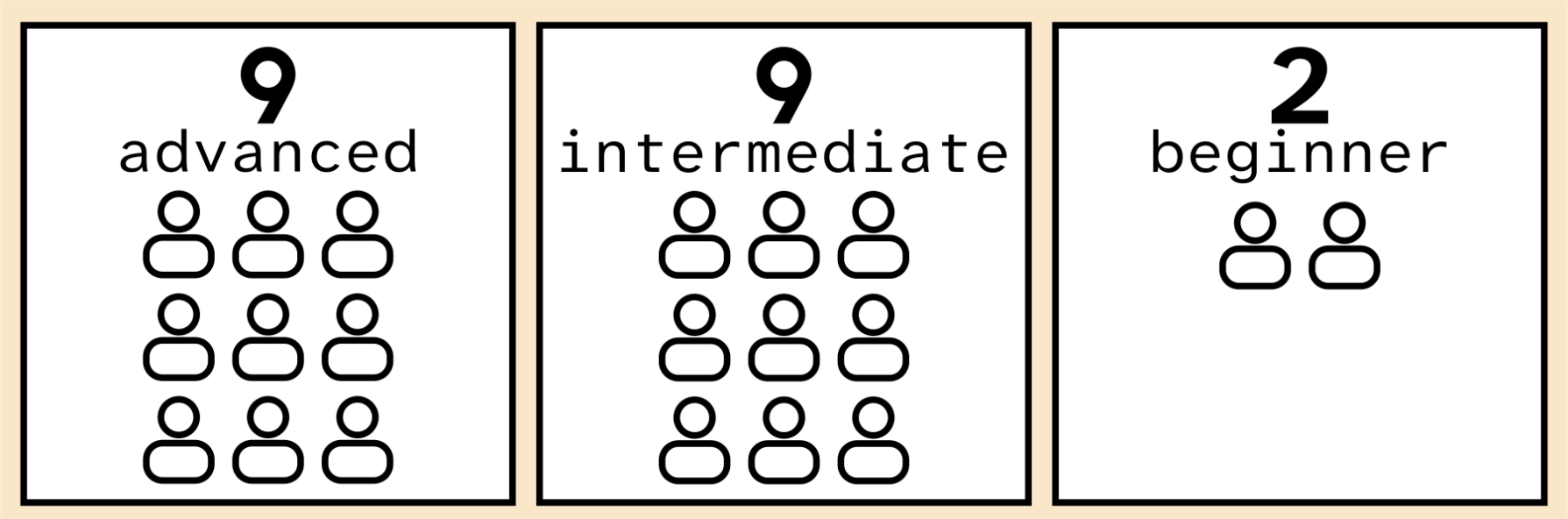
02 designers can’t see the future

- Usability tests: a handful of people, for about an hour
- But tools live in a busy world of people, places and things

> "It isn’t only that we use tools; we think with them." — Alva Noë

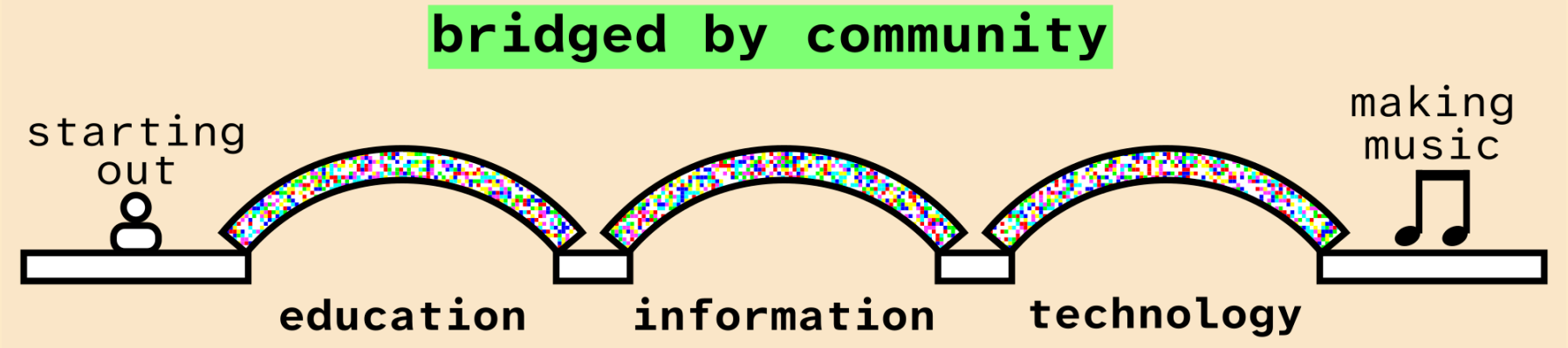
We can't fully anticipate how a tool will be used until it's in use.

03 20 sound creatives



All blind or visually impaired · 9 countries · 2-hour interviews and demos

04 three gaps



> "There is a lot of goodwill without the backup." — Peter Bosher

05 communities build the bridges

1. **Mailing lists and WhatsApp groups** for each DAW (digital audio workstation)
2. **OSARA**: community-built screen-reader access for the Reaper DAW
3. **Thousands of preset files**, made by hand, so a synth can be browsed by ear

> "The WhatsApp groups are very voice message focused." — Rory McDonald

A DAW is often accessible only with the community's knowledge.

Sighted users get a working product at the point of purchase.

07 Illich: *Tools for Conviviality*

A convivial tool is:

1. Easy to learn by using it
2. Used when and where **you** choose
3. Adaptable to **you**

…and community is at its heart.

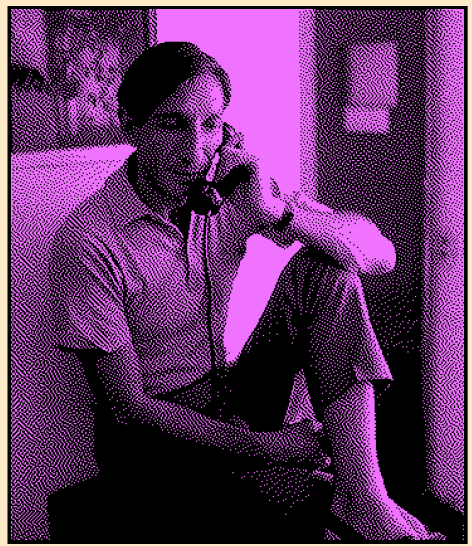


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08 three design guidelines

GUIDELINE 1	GUIDELINE 2	GUIDELINE 3
build accessible ecosystems Tutorials and manuals without visual cues	**embrace interdependent access** Credit community work, and point people to it	**design for designers** Open extension points: the DAW is ajar

Make tools malleable, and support the communities who change them.

"Nothing about us without us", where **us** is a community.

thank you!



feedback, 2 minutes
noiseguaranteed.org/assets26/feedback



slides and script
noiseguaranteed.org/assets26

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